

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 619

By Hensley

A RESOLUTION to recognize and address the importance of substance abuse prevention education.

WHEREAS, the State of Tennessee is in a crisis, overtaken by substance abuse, including alcohol abuse, and mental health disorders; and

WHEREAS, the Tennessee Together Student Survey of 2022-2023 reported that one in fifteen students had misused prescription drugs, with 8.5 percent of students reporting that at least one of their closest friends had used prescription drugs not prescribed to them in the past school year; and

WHEREAS, the same survey reported that 29.8 percent of Tennessee students had vaped nicotine, 13 percent had vaped marijuana, and 14.4 percent had vaped flavoring only, with the average age of initiation to vaping to be 13.8 years of age; and

WHEREAS, the survey further showed that approximately one in three students in Tennessee had reported drinking alcohol, with an average age of initiation to be 13.4 years of age; and

WHEREAS, in 2022-2023, 1,138,000 Tennesseans over the age of twelve were classified as needing substance use treatment, with only 318,000 receiving treatment, including 31,000 between twelve and seventeen years of age; and

WHEREAS, prevention education should begin in kindergarten, educating and empowering our children to make healthy choices, as seventy-four percent of substance abuse begins by age seventeen, with ten percent beginning by age eleven; and

WHEREAS, when we spend time building positive childhood experiences, it reduces negative health outcomes later in life for our children; and

WHEREAS, effective preventions that work in schools include long-term, evidence-based programs that start as early as kindergarten and continue through grade twelve; a social-emotional learning curriculum that includes decision-making, problem solving, and emotional regulations skills; mental health integration that provides access to professionals for one-on-one student support, specifically for issues like domestic violence, bullying, and suicidal thoughts, etc.; accessibility that is embedded in existing health and physical education curricula, with resources available to parents and communities; and community connections that link students and families to coalitions and local support services; and

WHEREAS, prevention education reduces the economic burden on the State of Tennessee while fostering healthier communities; every \$1.00 spent on prevention saves \$4.60-\$18.00 in healthcare and criminal justice costs; and

WHEREAS, prevention saves lives, breaks generational cycles, and secures a healthier future for Tennessee; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that it is vital to the future of the State of Tennessee and its citizens that we commit to do whatever it takes to reverse the alcohol and drug addiction rate that has been growing for the last seventy years in Tennessee.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that due to the information gathered via the Tennessean Youth Survey and reviewed by the Tennessee Prevention Coalition, we fully support and recommend that a long-term early intervention program that follows the student through graduation with an evidence-based drug prevention, life skills training, and violence prevention program be implemented into the required curricula in our schools.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that appropriate copies of this resolution be transmitted to the commissioner of the Tennessee Department of Education and the executive director of the State Board of Education.